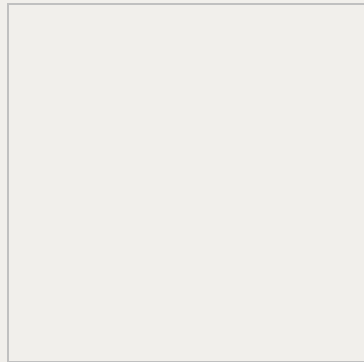


IN PROFILE

Prosper Mérimée

Mérimée (1803–1870) was a genuine polymath: a government official, man of letters, historian, and translator. In his work as the inspector-general of historical monuments, he was instrumental in founding the National Museum of the Middle Ages and restoring the citadel of Carcassonne. The Base Mérimée is the official database of French monuments. As a writer, he is best remembered as a pioneer of the novella. Published in 1845, his *Carmen* was based on a story told to him by the Countess of Montijo on his visit to Spain in 1830.



PORTRAIT OF PROSPER MERIMEE, SIMON ROCHART, 1852

Born in Paris, the son of a singing teacher, Georges Bizet received his early musical training from his parents and uncle, all accomplished musicians. In 1848, aged nine, he was admitted to the Paris Conservatoire and was an exceptional student, winning prizes for piano, organ, and composition.